# D – Changes to Ballot Measure Process

**Shall the City amend the Charter to increase the requirements for signature initiatives from 2% to 8% of registered voters in San Francisco (currently from about 10,600 to about 42,500 signatures), increase the requirements for calling special elections, allow signature initiatives to be withdrawn before an election, and remove the ability of a minority of Board of Supervisors members or the Mayor to place measures on the ballot?**

| | |
|---|---|
| **YES** | ◯ |
| **NO** | ◯ |

This measure requires 50%+1 affirmative votes to pass.

## Digest by the Ballot Simplification Council

**The Way It Is Now:** The San Francisco Board of Supervisors (Board) has 11 members. A measure can be either an ordinance to change the law or a declaration of policy. Under the City Charter, measures can be placed on the ballot in several ways, including:

- By a majority vote of the Board;
- By four or more Board members without a Board vote;
- By the Mayor without a Board vote; or
- By a signature initiative (petition) signed by at least 2% of the registered voters in San Francisco, currently about 10,600 signatures.

Currently San Francisco has over 530,000 registered voters.

Signature initiatives usually appear on the ballot at the next regularly scheduled election.

Signature initiatives may call for an earlier "special" election on an ordinance if the petition is signed by at least 10% of the votes cast for all candidates for Mayor in the last election. Currently, this is about 39,000 signatures.

Once a signature initiative is submitted to the Department of Elections, it cannot be withdrawn.

**The Proposal:** Proposition D would amend the Charter to increase the requirements to put measures on the ballot by:

- Increasing the number of signatures required to place a signature initiative on the ballot from 2% to 8% (currently from about 10,600 to about 42,500 signatures) of the registered voters in San Francisco.
- Increasing the number of signatures required to call a special election on an ordinance from 10% of the votes cast for Mayor in the last election to 10% of the registered voters in San Francisco. Currently, this is about 53,100 signatures.

Proposition D would allow signature initiatives to be withdrawn up to 102 days before the election.

Proposition D would also change the requirements to put measures on the ballot by:

- Removing the ability of four or more Board members to place a measure on the ballot without a Board vote;
- Removing the ability of the Mayor to independently place a measure on the ballot;

The Board could still place measures on the ballot by a majority vote.

**A "YES" Vote Means:** If you vote "yes," you want to increase the requirements for signature initiatives from 2% to 8% of registered voters (currently from about 10,600 to about 42,500 signatures), increase the requirements for special elections, allow signature initiatives to be withdrawn, and remove the ability of a minority of Board members or the Mayor to place measures on the ballot.

**A "NO" Vote Means:** If you vote "no," you do not want to make these changes.

The above statement is an impartial analysis of this measure. Arguments for and against this measure immediately follow.
The full text begins on page 190. Some of the words used in the ballot digest are explained starting on page 62.

## Controller's Statement on "D"

City Controller Greg Wagner has issued the following statement on the fiscal impact of Proposition D:

Should the proposed Charter amendment be approved by the voters, in my opinion, it would have a minimal impact on the cost of government.

The proposed Charter amendment would (1) require the approval of a majority of the Board of Supervisors to place an ordinance on the ballot, (2) eliminate the Mayor's ability to directly place an ordinance on the ballot, (3) increase the voter signature threshold for initiatives from 2% to 8% (currently from about 10,600 to about 42,500 signatures) of the registered voters in San Francisco, (4) allow proponents to withdraw a measure after it qualifies for the ballot, and (5) raise the threshold for special elections from 10% of the votes for mayor in the last general municipal election to 10% of registered voters.

The proposed amendment is likely to reduce costs at levels that cannot be determined at this time. Since the proposed Charter amendment raises the voter signature threshold, fewer initiatives may qualify for the ballot which may reduce the volume of printed pages included in the voter information pamphlet (VIP). On average, each page in the VIP costs $11,400 to prepare, print, and distribute to all registered voters. The proposed increase in the voter signature threshold may also reduce the number of special elections called which would result in cost savings for the Department of Elections. The estimated minimum cost for a citywide special election is $5 million with a one-card ballot and less than 50-page VIP.

The proposed Charter amendment may impact the Department of Elections' workload. It may result in a reduction in ballot ordinances which would reduce the associated workload for the Department of Elections—freeing staff to work on other government functions. Conversely, the Department of Elections may see an increase in workload to validate more voter signatures for a measure to qualify for the ballot and to remove qualified measures at the proponents' request.

## How "D" Got on the Ballot

On July 23, 2026, the Department of Elections certified that the initiative petition calling for Proposition D to be placed on the ballot had a sufficient number of valid signatures to qualify the measure for the ballot.

53,076 signatures were required to place an initiative Charter Amendment on the ballot. This number is equal to 10% of the registered voters at the time a "Notice of Intent to Circulate Petition" was published. A random check of the signatures submitted by the proponents of the initiative petition prior to the July 6, 2026, submission deadline showed that the total number of valid signatures was greater than the number required.

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